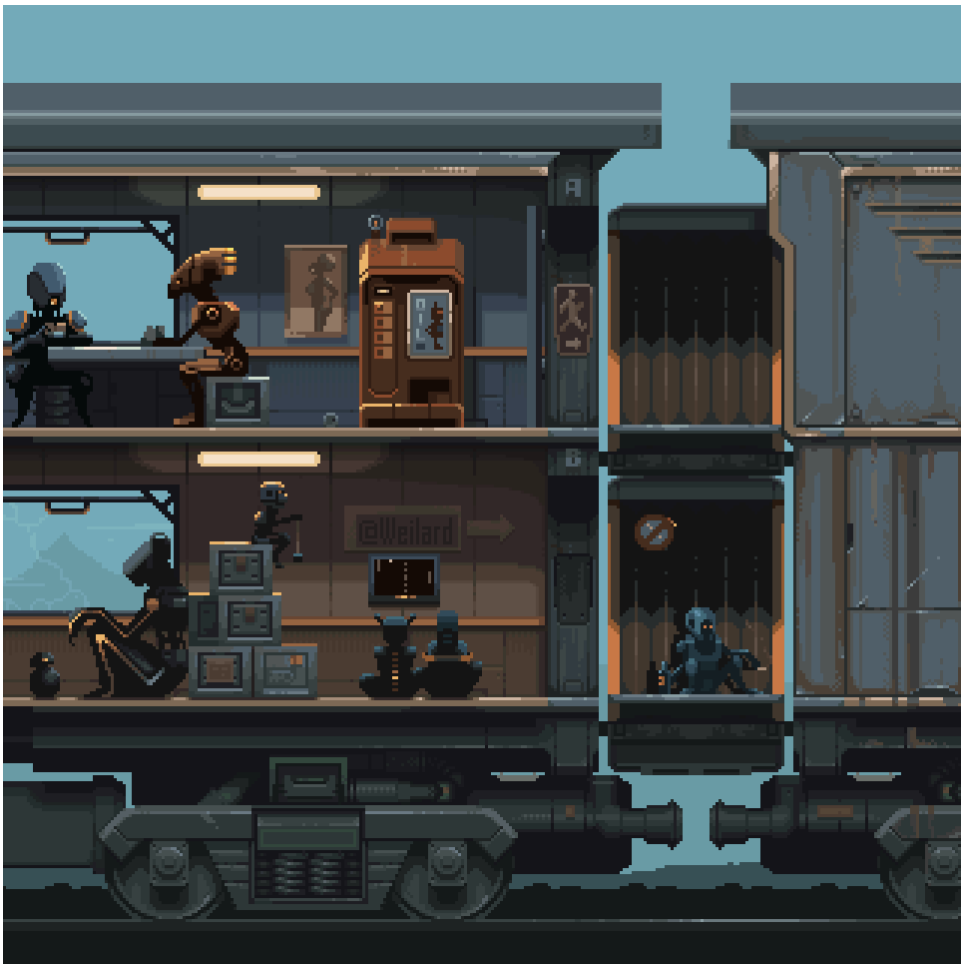
Game Design Document

Title & Group Details

- Game Title: Service Suspended Episode 3 : Blackout
- Team Name: The Uncanny Valley
- Group Members: Eswar Talasila, Nishil Rally, Mokshagna Kadiyala, Zachary Boston

Images



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Future Vintage Gaming

Game Overview

Game Name

Service Suspended Episode 3 : Blackout

Game Theme

Service Suspended: Episode 3 is an escape room set within a surreal, endlessly looping train cart. The player is stuck in a room after the Conductor captures them and locks them inside to prevent escape from the loop system. The Conductor has discovered the player's efforts to break free and has confined them to a windowless cart with seemingly no exit.

The player searches the room to find tools, hidden items, and lore fragments. The room is scattered with clues that reveal the true history of the loop system - where it started, who built it, and the fates of previous passengers who attempted to escape.

The game uses a point-and-click interface where you navigate between different views of the locked train cart. These views include the left and right walls, the overhead compartments, the floor level near the seats, and the locked door at the end of the cart. Clicking on objects in the environment either picks them up and adds them to your inventory, opens a closer examination view for lore items, or triggers an interaction like opening a panel or entering a code. The inventory bar sits along the bottom of the screen and players can select an item from it and then click on something in the environment to try using it. Some interactions require combining two inventory items together before they become useful.

The ticket system from Episode 2 is replaced by the clock puzzle being able to loop through different time zones of the loop.

The game explores themes of routine as confinement, bureaucratic absurdity, and metamorphosis through repetition. The episode ends with the player escaping the room, armed with golden tickets and knowledge of the loop system, leading into Episode 4's resource management game.

Key Points

- An escape room that challenges players to search a confined, surreal locked train cart using observation, item combination, and loop manipulation.
- The protagonist is the same ordinary office worker trapped in the loops since Episode 1.
- Players change clock times to trigger room rotations, changing the layout and revealing hidden items, clues, and new puzzle states.
- Close-up interaction scenes allow detailed examination of objects - a pseudo-3D/perspective view triggered by pressing E on points of interest.
- The room contains lore items that piece together the origin of the loop system and the fates of previous passengers.

- Core mechanics: observation, inventory management, cross-referencing clues across room variants, and puzzle mini-games.
- Puzzles include a clock mechanism, a jigsaw map assembly, a combination lock, and environmental interactions.
- Short playtime of 10-15 minutes, designed as the third game in a four-game franchise.
- The episode ends with the player escaping the room and realizing they must use golden tickets and accumulated knowledge to escape the system entirely.

Game Description

The game begins immediately after Episode 2's ending. The Conductor has locked the player in a windowless cart - a small, claustrophobic space that feels familiar but wrong. The same commute, compressed into a single room.

At first, the cart seems bare. The player walks around the room in the familiar top-down pixel art view, approaching objects of interest. Pressing E on an interactable object transitions to a close-up interaction scene - a detailed, perspective-style view of the object that allows direct manipulation. These close-up scenes are where items are found, puzzles are solved, and lore is discovered.

Lore items surface gradually: crumpled notes, stamped tickets with dates that don't add up, a logbook written in a hand that changes mid-entry. These fragments tell the story of the loop system and contain embedded clues needed to solve the room's puzzles.

As the player uncovers more secrets, the environment grows stranger. Shadows don't match their sources. The PA system announces stops that were never on the map. The cart is becoming something else. The episode ends with the player in possession of golden tickets and the knowledge to use them, closing on a moment of tense, quiet resolve before Episode 4.

Core Mechanics

Room Navigation (Top-Down)

The player navigates the locked cart in the same top-down pixel art view as Episodes 1 and 2. WASD movement, 8-directional character animation, and the familiar custom cursor carry over. The room contains multiple interactable hotspots marked with visual cues (subtle glow, prompt icon on proximity).

Close-Up Interaction Scenes

Pressing E on a hotspot transitions to a close-up scene which is a detailed view of the object or area, rendered in a pseudo-3D perspective style while remaining 2D pixel art. These scenes function like point-and-click adventure game screens:

- The player can click on sub-elements within the scene to examine, pick up, or manipulate them.
- Items found in close-up scenes are added to the inventory.
- Some scenes contain puzzle mini-games (clock, wiring, combination lock).
- Pressing Escape or a back button returns to the top-down room view.
- Close-up scenes change based on the current room variant - different items and states are visible in different rotations.

Room Rotation (Clock System)

The ticket system from Episode 2 is replaced by the clock puzzle being able to loop through. Rotating the room to a new variant. The room has 3 variants, each with different:

- Item placements and hidden objects in close-up scenes
- Lore fragments and notes
- Puzzle states (e.g., the clock shows different times, different drawers are accessible)
- Environmental details (lighting, shadows, ambient sounds)

Also newly introduced puzzles will require looping in terms of solving the puzzles so for example the clock puzzle might require the player to loop until the hands on a clock match.

Rotating is essential to find all items and clues, but each rotation costs a ticket. The player starts with a limited number of tickets and needs golden tickets to escape, creating a resource tension throughout the episode.

Inventory System

Items collected from close-up scenes are stored in the player's inventory (carried over UI from Episode 2). Items include:

- Lore items (notes, logbook pages, stamped tickets) - provide story context and embedded puzzle clues
- Map fragments - torn pieces of paper that assemble into a map of the loop system (jigsaw puzzle)
- Key items - objects needed to solve specific puzzles (e.g., a key, a screwdriver, a fuse)
- Golden tickets - found across room variants/puzzle variants, required to escape

Puzzles

1. Clock Puzzle

Location: Wall-mounted clock in the cart (close-up scene)

Mechanic: The clock hands can be rotated by clicking and dragging. Setting the correct time unlocks a hidden compartment behind the clock face.

Clue Source: Different room variants reveal time-related clues - a schedule pinned to a wall in variant 1, a timestamp on a lore note in variant 2, a PA announcement referencing a departure time in variant 3. The player must cross-reference these to determine the correct time.

Reward: A key item or golden ticket hidden in the compartment.

2. Jigsaw Map Assembly

Location: A flat surface (desk or floor area) where fragments can be placed (close-up scene)

Mechanic: Torn paper fragments are scattered across all room variants, hidden in close-up scenes (behind seat cushions, inside compartments, under floor panels, tucked into books). Each variant contains 1-2 fragments. Collecting them all allows the player to assemble a map of the loop system in a drag-and-drop jigsaw mini-game.

Clue Source: The fragments themselves - the player visually matches torn edges and content. Some lore notes describe locations that help identify where pieces go.

Reward: The completed map reveals the exit mechanism and serves as a required item for the final escape sequence. Also delivers major lore about the loop system's structure.

3. Combination Lock

Location: A locked safe or padlock on a sealed compartment (close-up scene)

Mechanic: A multi-digit combination lock. The player rotates digit wheels by clicking. The combination is not found as a single clue - it must be pieced together from multiple lore items found across different room variants.

Clue Source: A logbook entry mentions a "passenger number," a stamped ticket shows a route code, a note references a specific date. The combination is assembled from these disparate sources, requiring the player to read and cross-reference collected lore.

Reward: Contains a critical item needed for the escape sequence (e.g., a fuse, a lever handle).

4. Environmental / Wire Puzzle

Location: An exposed panel near the door mechanism (close-up scene)

Mechanic: A circuit or wiring puzzle where the player must cut wires in the right order to break the locking circuit for the exit door.

Clue Source: The completed jigsaw map shows the circuit order. Items from other puzzles (fuse from combination lock, wire cutters found in a variant) are required to interact with the panel.

Reward: Unlock the door. Triggers the ending sequence.

5. Loop-Gated Discovery

Location: Throughout all room variants

Mechanic: Not a single puzzle but the meta-challenge of the entire episode. The player must strategically rotate through room variants to find all required items and clues. Some items only appear in specific variants. The player needs to track what they've found and what they still need, then decide when to spend a ticket to rotate.

Tension: Tickets are finite. Golden tickets found across variants are needed to escape in Episode 4. Burning regular tickets to rotate reduces the player's future resources. This creates a risk/reward dynamic which allows for exploration more now at the cost of future flexibility.

Room Variants

The locked cart has 3 variants, cycled through by burning tickets:

	Variant A	**Variant B**	**Variant C**
Lighting	Dim fluorescent, flickering	Warm amber, single overhead bulb	Cold blue, emergency lighting
Accessible Areas	Overhead compartments open, floor panel sealed	Floor panel loose, overhead sealed	Side panel removable, desk drawer unlocked
Lore Items	Crumpled schedule, passenger logbook (pg 1-3)	Stamped tickets with impossible dates, logbook (pg 4-6)	PA system transcript, final logbook entry

Close-Up Interaction Scenes

Each hotspot in the room transitions to a detailed close-up scene:

Scene	**Description**	**Contains**
Wall Clock	Close-up of an ornate wall clock with manipulable hands	Clock puzzle, hidden compartment
Desk / Table	Surface where map fragments are assembled	Jigsaw map puzzle, lore notes in drawers
Overhead Compartment	Luggage rack with bags and hidden items	Map fragments, lore items, key items (variant-dependent)
Floor Panel	Loose floor section revealing hidden space beneath	Map fragments, golden ticket (variant-dependent)
Door Mechanism	Exposed wiring panel next to the locked door	Wire puzzle (final puzzle), requires items from other puzzles

Game Flow

Opening: Fade in from Episode 2's ending. The player is in the locked cart. Brief internal monologue establishes the situation.

Exploration Phase: Player walks around the room, discovers interactable hotspots, enters close-up scenes, collects initial items and lore from the default variant.

First Rotation: Player burns a ticket to rotate the room. New items and clue states appear. The player begins cross-referencing lore.

Puzzle Solving: Player uses collected clues to solve the clock puzzle and combination lock. Jigsaw map assembly progresses as fragments are found across rotations.

Final Rotation(s): Player rotates to find remaining fragments and items. Completes the jigsaw map. Collects golden tickets.

Escape Sequence: Player uses accumulated items to solve the wire puzzle at the door mechanism. The door unlocks.

Ending: Brief cutscene or text sequence. The player escapes the cart, realizes they must use golden tickets to escape the loop system entirely. Fade to black. "See you in Episode 4."

Technical Implementation Notes

- Built in Godot 4.6 (GL Compatibility), same engine and project as Episode 2.
- Reuses existing systems: GameState singleton, ticket punch system, section rotation, inventory UI, dialogue manager, cursor management, pause menu, mute toggle.
- Room variants use the same section swap architecture as Episode 2 dungeon floors - 1 room, 3 variant scenes swapped on ticket punch.
- Close-up scenes are separate scene files loaded as overlays (CanvasLayer) on top of the room, with their own input handling.
- Puzzle mini-games are self-contained scenes with their own scripts, instanced within close-up scene overlays.
- Lore items use a similar pattern to Episode 2's dialogue system - collected items stored in GameState, viewable from inventory.
- The jigsaw map is a drag-and-drop interface using Godot's Control nodes and input event handling.

Tasks

Genre: Escape Room / Puzzle | Platform: Godot 4.6 | Team Size: 4

Category	Task	Date	Assigned To	Status
Core Mechanics	Room navigation, E-interaction system, close-up scene transitions	3/22	Zachary Boston, Eswar Talasila	Completed

Core Mechanics	Ticket rotation system (adapted from Ep2 section swap)	3/22	Zachary Boston, Eswar Talasila	Completed
Core Mechanics	Inventory system updates (lore items, map fragments, key items)	3/22	Zachary Boston, Eswar Talasila	Completed
Assets	Room top-down tileset and painting (3 variants)	3/20	Zachary Boston	Started
Assets	Close-up scene artwork (5 scenes, variant-depende nt states)	3/20	Zachary Boston, Mokshagna Kadiyala	Started
Assets	Lore item artwork and text writing	3/20	Nishil Rally, Eswar Talasila	Started
Assets	Puzzle mini-game artwork (clock face, map fragments, wire panel)	3/20	Zachary Boston, Mokshagna Kadiyala	Started
Puzzles	Clock puzzle implementation	3/25	Eswar Talasila, Zachary Boston	Started
Puzzles	Jigsaw map assembly implementation	3/25	Zachary Boston	Started
Puzzles	Combination lock implementation	3/25	Eswar Talasila	Started
Puzzles	Wire puzzle implementation	3/25	Zachary Boston	Started
Game Flow	Opening sequence and ending cutscene	3/30	Eswar Talasila, Nishil Rally	Started
Game Flow	Lore item discovery scripting and placement	3/30	Nishil Rally, Eswar Talasila	Started
Testing	Full playthrough (solve path + fail	3/30	Everyone	Not Started

	states, 10-15 min target)			
Presentation	Presentation prep	4/1	Everyone	Not Started